
The Gen AI Money Playbook

How to turn what you learned over the weekend into real income — through freelancing, products, content, agencies, and roles that didn't exist twenty-four months ago

Generative AI Mastermind · Outskill · For Attendees

- ◆ **A field manual for:** Builders, freelancers and founders — US edition, global-ready
 - 🕒 **Read time:** ~45 minutes. Then re-read every quarter
 - 📖 **Inside:** Eight monetization paths · \$ pricing frameworks · outreach scripts · a 90-day roadmap
 - ✓ **The rule:** Pick one path, commit for ninety days, ship publicly
-

1. You Did the Weekend. Now Do the Work.

Over the past two days you were handed something most professionals will not touch for another two years: a working command of foundation models, custom GPTs, Gemini Gems, prompt engineering, vibe-coding, and image-and-video generation workflows. That is the input. **This document is the output.**

The truth is uncomfortable: most people who attend a workshop will go home, post a celebratory selfie, and never ship. The skills decay. The tab gets closed. Six months later, the only thing that survived the weekend is the certificate.

This playbook exists so that does not happen to you. It is a tactical, opinionated map for converting what you now know into dollars — through eight distinct paths, with platforms, prices, scripts, and a 90-day roadmap. You will not need to do all eight. **You will need to pick one, commit for ninety days, and ship publicly.** That is the whole game.

How to use this

Read §2–3 to orient. Skim §4 (the eight paths). Pick **one** path that fits your life right now. Then operate from §5 onwards — that's where the systems live. Re-read every quarter.

Who this is for: working professionals who want a side income or a path out of their current role; founders who want to add an AI line item to their P&L this quarter; students who want to graduate with paid client work, not just a résumé. Wherever you are, the rule is the same: *skill becomes income only when it touches the market. Stop polishing in private. Start charging.*

"The best time to monetize a skill is the week you learn it. The second-best time is right now."

2. A Window Most People Will Miss

Every technology shift creates a small window where the people who learned early get paid disproportionately. Mobile (2009–2011). Cloud (2011–2014). Crypto (2017–2018). Gen AI is in that window **right now** — and in the US, the gap between the demand for applied AI and the people who can actually deliver it is the widest it has ever been.

Number	What it means
\$1,500	Typical first AI freelance project for a working professional in the US.
\$5,000+	What a polished AI freelancer can charge per Custom GPT build on Upwork or Contra — and direct clients pay even more.

Number	What it means
3 million+	Custom GPTs live in the GPT Store. Most are bad. The well-built, well-distributed ones win.
2× salary	Common uplift for in-house "AI champions" who automate workflows and own the narrative.
\$3,000 / mo	A single SMB client on a monthly productized AI ops retainer.
90 days	Realistic timeline from "I just learned this" to first paying client — if you ship publicly.

2.1 Why most people still fail to monetize

- **1. They learn in private and never ship in public.** No portfolio, no proof, no inbound. The market cannot find you if you do not exist online.
- **2. They sell tools, not outcomes.** Nobody buys "I know ChatGPT." They buy "I will save your sales team 20 hours a week."
- **3. They stay generalist.** "AI for everyone" is "AI for nobody." The money is in the niche.
- **4. They under-price out of fear, then can't raise rates.** A \$300 client trains the market — and your nervous system — to expect \$300.
- **5. They wait to feel "ready."** Readiness is a feeling that arrives only after you have done the thing eleven times.

The reframe

You are not "learning AI." You are **arbitraging a skill gap**. Most teams in most companies in most cities still cannot prompt their way out of a paragraph. You can. That gap is your business.

3. Eight Ways to Get Paid for What You Just Learned

Each path uses a different mix of skills from the Mastermind. Each suits a different life stage. Read the table, find the row that fits, then jump to its deep-dive.

#	Path	In one line	Money
01	Freelance AI Specialist	Sell your AI skills as bespoke project work — fastest path to first revenue	\$1,000–\$10,000 / project

#	Path	In one line	Money
02	Productized AI Services	Same scope, same price, every time. Recurring revenue without bespoke chaos	\$1,000–\$8,000 / month
03	AI Creator & Personal Brand	Build an audience around AI; monetize via consults, courses, sponsorships	\$10K–\$100K in year 1
04	Vibe-Coded Micro-SaaS	Ship small, focused tools with Cursor, v0, Lovable, Bolt	\$500–\$10,000 MRR target
05	Custom GPTs & Gemini Gems	Build niche assistants for specific workflows; sell builds, access, or leads	\$1,000–\$5,000 / build
06	AI Content & Video Production	Image/video generation as a service for D2C brands, agencies, creators	\$1,500–\$6,000 / month
07	Cohorts, Communities & Coaching	Teach what you've shipped — paid 1:1s, Skool, cohorts, paid circles	\$10K–\$100K / cohort
08	In-House AI Champion	Stay employed; become the AI person; negotiate the uplift	+30–100% comp

How to pick

Working professional with low spare time: **Path 01, 05 or 08**. Founder: **02 or 04**. Student: **01 → 03**. Already creating content: **03 + 07**.

The wrong path beaten to death beats the right path never started.

4. The Eight Paths, In Depth

Path 01 — The Freelance AI Specialist

Sell your AI skills as project work. This is the path with the lowest activation energy and the fastest time-to-revenue. Most attendees should start here, even if they end up at Path 02 or 03 long-term. **Best for:** working pros and students · **Time to first \$:** 2–6 weeks · **Standard range:** \$1,000–\$5,000 per project · **Premium clients:** \$5,000–\$20,000 for multi-workflow systems.

Skills from the Mastermind, mapped to revenue: prompting → prompt engineering as a service; Custom GPTs/Gems → niche assistant builds; vibe-coding → rapid landing pages, internal tools, MVPs; image/video gen → ad creative, thumbnails, b-roll, course visuals; multiple models → a credible "I'll pick the right tool for your job."

Ten services you can sell this week:

- **1. Custom GPT for a specific workflow** — sales prospecting, legal contract review, listing descriptions for real estate.
- **2. AI cold email / LinkedIn DM systems** — Apollo + AI personalization, 1,000+ qualified sends a week.
- **3. Faceless YouTube content engines** — topic research → script → AI voice → AI b-roll. Finance, history, true crime, business.
- **4. D2C ad creative packs** — 10–20 image/video ad variants per month for performance teams.
- **5. Internal AI training + SOPs for SMB teams** — half-day workshop + Notion playbook + 3 custom GPTs.
- **6. Workflow automation (n8n / Make + AI)** — inbox triage, lead routing, content repurposing, reporting.
- **7. AI customer support chatbot** — trained on the company's docs, deployed to website + support inbox.
- **8. Newsletter content engine setup** — Beehiiv / Substack + AI research and drafting flow.
- **9. SEO content engines** — keyword research → outline → draft → polish; 20 articles a month.
- **10. Resume / LinkedIn / portfolio rewrites** — lower-ticket but high-volume; great for your first 10 testimonials.

The 90-day launch sequence:

Days	Move
01–07 • Niche	Pick one industry (D2C, real estate, edtech, law, finance creators). Build 3 spec pieces — fake-client work that proves the outcome.
08–14 • Setup	Profile on Upwork + Contra + LinkedIn featured + a Calendly booking link. One vibe-coded portfolio page. Stripe for invoicing.
15–30 • Outbound	20 LinkedIn DMs/day · 10 cold emails/day · 3 posts/week. First 2–3 clients at \$1,000 each — go cheap, get testimonials.
31–60 • Refine	Raise prices 2×. Tighten niche. Document delivery. Ask happy clients for warm intros.
61–90 • Retainer	Convert 1–2 project clients into \$2,500+/month retainers. Stop selling hours. Sell outcomes.

⚠ The Path 01 pitfall

The mistake every Path 01 freelancer makes is hiding behind Upwork. The real money is in LinkedIn DMs and warm intros, where there's no race-to-the-bottom bidding. Marketplaces are training wheels — get on, build proof, then ride out into direct outreach.

Path 02 — Productized AI Services

A productized service is a service that behaves like a product: same scope, same price, same delivery — every time. You stop quoting projects and start selling subscriptions. This is how the smartest freelancers escape the per-project grind. **Best for:** founders and senior freelancers · **Time to launch:** 3–8 weeks · **SMB retainer:** \$1,000–\$5,000/month · **Mid-market & funded startups:** \$5,000–\$15,000/month.

Productized offers that work in 2026:

- **1. AI-powered LinkedIn ghostwriting** — \$2,500/month, 8 posts a week, voice-trained on the founder. Hot for founders, B2B sales leaders, VCs.
- **2. Custom GPT for your team** — \$3,500 flat, two-week delivery, includes training and SOP. Sells itself once you have one case study.
- **3. AI ad creative engine** — \$3,000/month, 30 image + 10 video ad variants for D2C brands. Show CTR uplift.
- **4. AI SEO content engine** — \$2,500/month, 20 long-form articles, full pipeline. Charge by deliverable, not hours.
- **5. Faceless YouTube channel-in-a-box** — \$5,000 setup + \$2,500/month operations. Finance, history, true crime and business niches are wide open.
- **6. AI cold outbound system** — \$3,000/month: 3,000 personalized emails, lead lists, deliverability. B2B will pay for booked meetings, not "campaigns."
- **7. AI customer support, deployed** — \$4,000 setup + \$1,500/month maintenance. Sell ticket-deflection % as the headline metric.

The productization framework: Pick the one service from your freelance phase you can deliver in your sleep, with the highest margin → Document the SOP in Notion (every step, every prompt, every tool) → **Page:** vibe-code a one-page sales site (hero · outcome · process · price · CTA) → **Proof:** two case studies, numbers not adjectives → **Distribute:** LinkedIn posts 3×/week + 50 cold DMs/week + 1 partnership/month → **Hire:** at 3 retainers, bring in a contractor at 30% of revenue to deliver. Now you have a business.

The leap (the whole point of this path)

3 freelance clients at \$3,000 = \$9,000 — but you delivered all of it yourself. 3 retainer clients at \$3,000 = \$9,000, delivered by a contractor at 30% cost = **\$6,300 of margin and free time.** That's the whole game.

Path 03 — The AI Creator & Personal Brand

An audience is the closest thing to a financial superpower an individual can build in 2026. The path is slow for the first six months and then it compounds violently. **Best for:** anyone with patience · **Time to first \$:** 3–9 months · **Year 1:** \$10K–\$100K · **Year 3:** \$100K–\$1M+.

Channels that work: **LinkedIn** (the B2B treasure — consulting income, B2B leads, hiring offers; 5–7 posts/week); **YouTube** (long-form authority — course sales, sponsorships; 1–2 videos/week, "I tried X for 30 days" formats win); **X/Twitter** (global tech audience — ship-in-public with screenshots of receipts); **Instagram + Shorts** (mass reach — 1 reel/day minimum); **Newsletter** (your owned land — Beehiiv or Substack, one every Sunday; the list is the asset).

Stage	How you earn
0–1,000 followers	Free everything. Build proof, collect testimonials, do not monetize. Ship 5+ pieces a week.
1K–5K	Soft monetization: paid 1:1 consults at \$50–\$150/30 min (Intro, Superpeer, or Calendly + Stripe); free PDFs for emails; affiliate links to AI tools.
5K–25K	Owned products: cohort courses (\$300–\$1,500/seat), sponsorships (\$500–\$5,000/integration), templates.
25K–100K+	Empire stage: paid community, SaaS, agency, books, brand deals, advisory. Distribution is now your moat.

Content formulas that work: "I tried [tool] for [time] — here's what happened" · "[Job role] in 2026 needs these 5 AI workflows" · before/after screenshots of a vibe-coded build · "\$0 to \$X with [path] — week-by-week" · contrarian takes against the hype.

⚠ **The content law**

You cannot half-ass this path. 5–7 pieces a week, minimum, for 6 months before you judge whether it's working. Every creator who quits at month 3 was 90 days from compounding. Treat content as a non-negotiable, not a hobby.

Path 04 — Vibe-Coded Micro-SaaS

Until 2024, building a SaaS required a co-founder, six months, and capital. In 2026, you can ship a working tool in a weekend using Cursor, v0, Lovable, Bolt, or Replit Agent. Most micro-SaaS will fail — that's fine. The cost of failure is now small enough that you can run 3–5 launches a year and let the winners compound. **Best for:** builders and founders · **Time to launch:** 1 weekend–4 weeks · **Per-tool MRR:** \$50–\$5,000 · **Portfolio target:** 3–5 launches/year.

The micro-SaaS hunting formula

Pick a narrow audience (real estate agents in Phoenix, indie YouTubers under 5K subs, boutique CPA firms). Find a workflow they hate that takes 30+ minutes a week. Wrap it in an AI flow. Charge \$9 / \$19 / \$49 a month. Don't try to please everyone — please one tribe so much that they evangelize you.

Build stack: Cursor + Next.js + Supabase + Stripe — or full-vibe with Lovable/v0/Bolt, hosted on Vercel.

AI stack: Claude / OpenAI APIs for inference. **Payments:** Stripe — or Lemon Squeezy / Paddle as merchant of record so sales tax is handled for you. **Ops:** Cloudflare DNS, Resend email, PostHog analytics.

Where to launch: Product Hunt (day-1 spike), Hacker News (Show HN), BetaList (pre-launch), Microlaunch, Indie Hackers, r/SideProject. **Distribution:** X build-in-public daily, surgical Reddit posts in niche subs, LinkedIn founder-mode 3×/week, one YouTube tutorial (long tail), niche newsletter sponsorships, programmatic SEO (compounding).

Pricing tiers: Free (a generous hook with a real win) → Starter \$9/mo → Pro \$19/mo (where most revenue lives) → Team \$49/mo (seats + admin) → Annual prepay (2 months free) → Lifetime \$199 only at launch, only first 100 users.

⚠ Reality check

The hard part of micro-SaaS is not the building. It's the distribution. If you can't get 100 strangers excited about your idea, no AI tool will save you. Spend 50% of your time on distribution, even at launch. Especially at launch.

Path 05 — Custom GPTs & Gemini Gems

There are millions of Custom GPTs in the world. Almost all of them are bad — generic prompt wrappers no one uses twice. The opportunity is in the boring middle: building niche, well-trained, well-documented assistants for specific businesses, and getting paid for the build, not the listing. **Best for:** B2B-comfortable freelancers · **Time per build:** 1–3 weeks · **Per build:** \$1,000–\$5,000 · **3-GPT system:** \$5,000–\$10,000.

The two business models: **Model A — build-for-hire (recommended):** build a Custom GPT or Gem for a specific company, trained on their data, deployed inside their workflow; paid per build + optional retainer. This is where the money is. **Model B — build-for-distribution:** publish public GPTs targeting a niche and use them as top-of-funnel for consults, courses and inbound. Slower, but compounds.

High-demand niches: real estate (listing copy, lead qualifying), law firms (clause-checker, brief summarizer), D2C marketing (brand-voice ad copy), HR (JD writer, candidate screens), CPAs / financial advisors (tax explainer, client summaries), educators (graders, lesson plans), sales teams (discovery prompts, follow-up writers, CRM enrichment).

The build-for-hire workflow: pick a niche → find 30 SMBs in it (Sales Navigator, Google Maps, directories) → send a "free workflow audit" offer ("30-min call. I'll find 3 places AI saves your team 5+ hours a week. No pitch.") → audit their actual workflow → propose 1–3 GPTs, each tied to a time-saved number → build, train on their docs, deploy inside their tooling → hand over with a 30-min Loom + Notion SOP + 30-day check-in → sell the retainer: **"\$750/month and I keep these GPTs sharp + ship one new one a quarter."**

Pricing anchor

A single well-built GPT for a real estate brokerage in Austin should price at \$2,000–\$3,500. A 3-GPT system + 4-hour team training + Notion playbook should price at \$7,500–\$10,000 flat. Do not underprice: the buyer is comparing you to a junior hire (\$4,000+/month, full year) — not to a YouTube tutorial.

Path 06 — AI Content & Video Production

Image and video generation tools have collapsed the cost of production: a two-person team can now ship the creative output of a 10-person agency. If you came out of the Mastermind comfortable with image and video models and AI voice — this is the path with the fastest visual proof and the most photogenic case studies. **Best for:** creators and designers · **Time to first \$:** 2–6 weeks · **Project price:** \$1,000–\$8,000 · **Retainer:** \$1,500–\$6,000/month.

Services you can sell:

- **1. D2C ad creative packs** — 10–30 image + 5–10 video variants/month for performance teams. \$2,500–\$5,000/month.
- **2. Faceless YouTube channel production** — finance, history, true crime, business niches. \$2,500–\$7,500/month per channel.
- **3. Short-form for B2B brands** — LinkedIn/Instagram videos with AI b-roll, voiceover, captions. \$1,500–\$4,000/month.
- **4. AI ecom photoshoots** — replace \$5,000+ studio shoots with AI lifestyle shots. \$1,500–\$5,000 per "shoot."
- **5. Course / cohort visuals** — decks, thumbnails, lesson covers for course creators. Easy retainer.
- **6. Music / lyric videos and album art** — indie musicians, podcast covers, audiograms.
- **7. UGC-style synthetic ads** — hot category; synthetic spokespeople for D2C. Disclose appropriately.

The tool stack: storyboarding — ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini · image — Midjourney, Imagen, Flux, Ideogram · video — Runway, Sora, Veo, Kling, Hailuo, Higgsfield, Luma · voice — ElevenLabs, Murf, Cartesia · music — Suno, Udio · edit — CapCut, DaVinci, Descript, OpusClip, Submagic.

Who to pitch: D2C brands doing performance ads (skincare, F&B, fashion); edtech and coaching businesses on YouTube; real estate agencies needing listing walkthroughs; finance/business YouTubers

tired of stock footage; B2B SaaS teams needing LinkedIn video; course creators on Whop, Skool, Maven, Kajabi; wedding photographers (AI mood boards, post-edit).

The portfolio hack

Pick 5 brands you'd love to work with. Make unsolicited spec creative for each — 3 ad variants you'd ship if they were already a client. DM the creative head with the work. Show, don't pitch. This converts at a shockingly high rate.

Path 07 — Cohorts, Communities & Coaching

The fastest-growing income category in the creator economy is "learn from someone who shipped." If you've used your Mastermind skills to deliver real outcomes — even on Path 01 or 02 — you can teach others how to do it. Margins are 90%+; the scale is 1-to-many; the hard prerequisite is having actually shipped. **Best for:** after 3+ months on Path 01/02/04 · **Cohort price:** \$300–\$1,500/seat · **Cohort revenue:** \$10K–\$100K/launch · **Community MRR:** \$1,000–\$15,000.

Four revenue models, ranked by effort:

- **1. Paid 1:1 coaching.** Easiest start: \$50–\$200/30 min via Intro, Superpeer, or Calendly + Stripe. Capped income but immediate — use it to validate that people will pay you for advice before scaling up.
- **2. Workshops & one-off events.** 3-hour workshops via Luma or Eventbrite at \$25–\$200/seat. Great for testing topics and warm leads.
- **3. Cohort courses.** Live, time-bound, small groups on Maven, Skool or Teachable. \$300–\$1,500/seat × 30–100 seats. This is where the money lives.
- **4. Paid communities.** Skool / Circle / Discord at \$29–\$99/month. Highest LTV, hardest to sustain — needs daily presence or moderators. Pair with a cohort.

Cohort topic	Why it works
AI for Lawyers	Niche-by-job-role: tight ICP, easy targeting, premium pricing.
ChatGPT for Realtors	Agents in secondary markets will pay \$300–\$800 to learn from someone who's been there.
Build Your First Custom GPT	Beginner-friendly, repeatable, easy to fill 100-seat cohorts at \$150 each.
AI Workflows for Founders	Premium audience at \$1,000–\$2,500/seat. Recorded testimonials sell the next cohort.
Faceless YT Channel in 30 Days	High-demand, results-driven, photogenic. Easy waitlist.

Cohort topic	Why it works
AI for HR & Recruiting	B2B-flavored, corporate sponsorship potential, easy upsell to internal training.

⚠ Don't teach what you just learned

Wait until you've shipped for at least 3 paying clients on Path 01 or 02 before you launch a cohort. Otherwise you're teaching theory. The market has had enough theory. Teach receipts.

Path 08 — The In-House AI Champion

Not everyone wants to leave their job. Not everyone should. The under-discussed monetization path is using your Mastermind skills inside your current employer — to engineer a 30–100% comp uplift, a new title, or a transition into roles that pay double. Done well, this is the highest-ROI path in the playbook.

Best for: working professionals · **Time horizon:** 3–9 months · **Risk:** lowest of all eight.

The 90-day in-house playbook: audit your team's workflows (list every recurring task taking 30+ minutes a week — those are your targets) → pick 3 and build Custom GPTs/Gems for them, trained on your team's docs, with time-saved quantified → run a 30-minute "lunch & learn", hand the team the GPTs, become the AI person by demonstration → document everything in Notion (workflow before, workflow after, time saved, cost saved — your case study) → post on LinkedIn with permission ("How we automated X at [Company]" — your manager looks like a leader, you become the visible face) → volunteer for the AI strategy conversation every leadership team is already having → negotiate explicitly: **"I saved the team N hours/week = \$X/year. I'd like a Y% raise / a new title / to lead the AI initiative."**

Emerging role	Scope	US comp
Head of AI Operations	Owens AI rollout across functions; often non-engineering	\$180K – \$350K
AI Product Manager	PM-flavored role focused on AI features; PM background + Mastermind = qualified	\$140K – \$250K
AI Solutions Architect	Often non-technical; maps business problems to AI solutions	\$160K – \$300K
AI Workflow Designer	Builds internal Custom GPTs / agents for ops, sales, HR	\$110K – \$190K
AI Enablement Lead	Trains the company on AI: internal cohorts + SOPs + audits	\$120K – \$220K

Emerging role	Scope	US comp
Prompt Engineer	Pure prompt + eval work; increasingly folded into other roles	\$100K – \$180K

The stack move

Path 08 is not exclusive. Stack it with Path 01, 03 or 05: use your day job as your case-study factory and your salary as your runway. Three months in, you'll either get the raise (great) or land a side income that exceeds your salary (also great).

5. The Platform Stack — Where to Live Online

A monetization business is a stack of platforms — for finding clients, delivering work, getting paid, and compounding distribution. Pick one per category. Don't sprawl across ten apps for the same job.

Category	Platforms (pick one)
Lead gen & audience	LinkedIn (B2B #1) · X/Twitter (global tech) · YouTube (authority) · Instagram & Shorts (mass reach) · Beehiiv/Substack newsletter (owned) · Reddit niche subs (surgical)
Freelance marketplaces	Upwork (volume) · Contra (no fees) · Fiverr / Fiverr Pro (productized) · Toptal (premium) · Braintrust (vetted networks) · Intro / Superpeer (paid 1:1)
Outreach / sales	LinkedIn Sales Navigator · Apollo.io (lead data) · Instantly / Smartlead (cold email) · Lemlist (personalized) · Hunter / Snov (email finder) · Clay (enrichment)
Payments & invoicing	Stripe (payments + invoicing) · Wave / FreshBooks (books) · Mercury (business banking) · Wise / Payoneer (cross-border) · Deel (contractor pay) · Lemon Squeezy / Paddle (MoR for SaaS)
Courses & community	Skool (community + course) · Circle (premium) · Maven (cohorts) · Teachable / Podia (self-paced) · Whop (creator products) · Luma / Eventbrite (workshops)
Portfolio & sites	v0 / Lovable / Bolt (vibe-coded) · Framer (designed) · Notion + Super.so (fastest) · Carrd (one-pager) · Beacons / Linktree (bio link)

Category	Platforms (pick one)
Productivity & delivery	Notion (SOPs & CRM) · Loom (async handoff) · Slack (client comms) · ChatGPT Plus / Team (daily driver) · Claude Pro (long-form) · Cursor (vibe-coding)
Launch (SaaS / tools)	Product Hunt (launch day) · Hacker News Show HN (traffic spike) · BetaList / Microlaunch (pre-launch) · Indie Hackers (community) · r/SideProject · X build-in-public

6. Ninety Days From Here to Your First \$

A specific, week-by-week plan. Adjust the path, but keep the structure. The single biggest mistake we see is people spending three months "preparing" without ever shipping. This roadmap is shipping-first.

Days 01–30 · Build the foundation

Week	Move
01 · Pick & commit	Pick one path. Pick one niche. Write a 1-line offer. Tell three people you're doing it — public commitment is fuel.
02 · Spec work	Build 3 spec pieces — fake-client work that proves the outcome you sell. Post each on LinkedIn / X with a breakdown.
03 · Set up shop	Vibe-code a portfolio. Write LinkedIn featured. Set up a Calendly booking link. Set up Stripe invoicing. Refresh every bio with the new offer.
04 · Begin outbound	10 cold DMs/day. 5 cold emails/day. 3 posts/week. The job this month is volume of contact.

Days 31–60 · Land & learn

Week	Move
05 · First conversion	Land your first paid client. Charge less than you'd like — this round is for proof, not income. Even \$500–\$1,500 is fine.
06 · Deliver hard	Over-deliver on the first project. Document everything. Record a Loom case study with their permission.
07 · Testimonials	Ask for a written + video testimonial. Post the case study publicly. One real outcome beats ten years of theory posts.

Week	Move
08 • Land 2 more	Use the case study to land clients 2 and 3. Raise your price 30–50%. By end of month 2: 3 paying clients, \$2,500–\$6,000 total revenue.

Days 61–90 • Scale the wins

Week	Move
09 • Productize	Pick your highest-margin offer. Productize it — fixed scope, fixed price, sales page.
10 • Retainer push	Pitch each existing client a monthly retainer. Even a 50% conversion = recurring revenue. Aim for \$2,500+/month MRR by week 12.
11 • Compound content	You now have receipts. Step up to 5–7 pieces/week. Write the case studies. Tag the clients. Watch inbound start.
12 • Decide	Review the data. Stay on this path? Layer on Path 03 (creator) or Path 02 (productize)? Decide. Plan the next 90 days.

7. What to Charge (\$)

Three pricing models. Use them all — pick the right one for the right deal. Pricing is a confidence game more than a math game, but knowing the math gives you the confidence.

Model	How it works	When to use it	Trap to avoid
Hourly	Sell time: \$50–\$300/hr depending on market and seniority	Discovery / consulting calls only — don't deliver projects this way	Penalizes you for getting better and faster
Project	Fixed scope, fixed price: \$1,000–\$10,000 per project	Anything with a clear deliverable; most freelance work	Scope creep without a change-order clause
Retainer	Monthly recurring fee for an outcome: \$1,500–\$8,000/month	Anyone you've delivered for once — always pitch this	Vague scope = burnout; define an hour-cap or deliverable-cap

7.1 SMB & small-team clients · typical ranges

Service	Project	Retainer / month
Custom GPT / Gem build	\$1,500 – \$5,000	\$500 – \$1,500
Productized service (writing / creative)	—	\$1,000 – \$8,000
AI consulting / advisory	\$2,000 – \$20,000	\$2,000 – \$10,000
Workflow automation (n8n + AI)	\$1,500 – \$10,000	\$800 – \$4,000
AI ad creative / video production	\$1,000 – \$8,000	\$1,500 – \$6,000

7.2 Funded startups & mid-market · typical ranges

Service	Project	Retainer / month
Custom GPT / Gem build	\$5,000 – \$25,000	\$1,500 – \$5,000
Productized service (writing / creative)	—	\$8,000 – \$25,000
AI consulting / advisory	\$20,000 – \$100,000	\$10,000 – \$30,000
Workflow automation (n8n + AI)	\$10,000 – \$50,000	\$4,000 – \$15,000
AI ad creative / video production	\$8,000 – \$40,000	\$6,000 – \$20,000

△ Same skill, different buyer: a build that earns \$2,000 from a local SMB earns \$10,000+ from a funded startup — price the buyer, not the hours. And run it like a business: set aside 25–30% for self-employment tax, pay quarterly estimates, and once income is real, an LLC + a separate business bank account keeps everything clean.

8. The Outreach Playbook — DMs, Emails, Looms

First contact is where most monetization dies. The fix is not longer messages or a copywriter. The fix is to be **specific, useful, and low-friction**. Scripts that get replies in 2026:

8.1 LinkedIn cold DM (best performer for B2B)

Hey {{first_name}} – saw your post on {{specific topic}}. Loved the {{specific point}} bit.

Quick one: a few {{their industry}} teams I've worked with were losing ~10 hrs/week on {{specific workflow}}. I built them a Custom GPT that cut that to 2.

Happy to share the playbook (no pitch, just the prompt + workflow).
Want me to send it over?

8.2 Cold email (outcome-led, four lines)

Subject: 12 hrs / week back for {{company}}?

Hi {{first_name}},

I help {{industry}} teams cut their {{specific workflow}} from 15 hours a week to under 3 – using Custom GPTs trained on their own SOPs.

Two examples: {{client A – outcome}}, {{client B – outcome}}.

Worth a 20-min call next week to see if the same applies to {{company}}?

– {{your name}}

8.3 Follow-ups (day 3 & day 7)

Day 3:

Hi {{first_name}} – bumping this. I built a quick Loom (3 min) showing exactly the workflow I'd set up for {{company}}. Want me to send it?

Day 7 (break-up):

Hi {{first_name}} – last note from me. If now isn't the right time, totally fair. Mind if I send the Loom anyway? You can keep it whether we work together or not.

The Loom hack — the biggest unlock in this playbook

Record a 2–3 minute Loom specifically for the prospect. Show their website / LinkedIn / company. Show the exact GPT or workflow you'd build. Send the link in your DM. Conversion rates run 3–10× higher than cold text — the Loom proves you've done the work, not just read the script.

The numbers that work

Daily target: 10 LinkedIn DMs + 5 cold emails + 1 Loom, five days a week, four weeks. Expect a 5–8% reply rate, 1–2% conversion to call, 30–50% close on calls. Math: ~300 contacts → ~15 calls → ~5 clients. That's the entire game.

9. The Seven Killers — What Stops You Getting Paid

Across hundreds of Mastermind attendees, the ones who fail to monetize fail in the same seven ways. Print this page. Stick it next to your laptop.

- **1. Tutorial-hopping.** Watching one more video instead of shipping. The market doesn't care how many courses you've completed — it cares what you've delivered. **Cure:** ban yourself from new courses for 90 days.
- **2. Selling the tool, not the outcome.** "I know ChatGPT" is not an offer; "I save your sales team 10 hours a week" is. **Cure:** rewrite every sentence in your pitch as a buyer outcome.
- **3. Generalist positioning.** "AI for businesses" is "AI for nobody." Pick one industry, one role, one workflow — get famous in that pinhole. **Cure:** write a 20-word ICP and tape it to your monitor.
- **4. Fear-pricing.** Quoting \$500 because you're scared they'll say no to \$5,000. Underpricing trains both your nervous system and the market. **Cure:** quote 30% higher than your gut; watch how few say no.
- **5. Hiding from outbound.** Every freelancer who fails is the one who waited for inbound. Cold outreach is unglamorous and it works. **Cure:** 50 contacts a week, non-negotiable, for 90 days.
- **6. Not collecting proof.** No testimonials, no screenshots, no Looms, no case studies — you're invisible without receipts. **Cure:** document every win within 24 hours of getting it.
- **7. Building in private.** Your portfolio is your daily LinkedIn / X / YouTube feed, not a hidden Notion page. **Cure:** ship 5 pieces a week — show the work, including the unfinished parts.

The meta-pitfall

All seven killers share one root: preferring the comfort of preparation to the discomfort of contact with the market. The market is the only honest teacher. Get rejected, get feedback, recalibrate. Repeat.

10. The Operator's Mindset

Skill plus mindset is what compounds; without the mindset, the skill rusts. Nine principles to internalize before you close this document:

- **1. Sell outcomes, not artifacts.** Nobody buys "a Custom GPT." They buy "12 hours back per week." Translate every offer.
- **2. Niche down ruthlessly.** "AI for D2C beauty brands under \$10M revenue" beats "AI consulting" — every single time.
- **3. Distribute as much as you build.** In 2026, distribution is the moat. The best builder with no audience loses to the average builder with one.
- **4. Ship in public.** Your build log is your portfolio. Your mistakes are your magnetism. Your output is your CV.
- **5. Charge what creates pressure to deliver.** Cheap clients pay you in cash but cost you in soul. Premium clients pay in cash, referrals, and standards.
- **6. Compound through testimonials.** One specific, named video testimonial beats ten anonymous "great work!" quotes. Collect aggressively.
- **7. Pick paths that stack.** Path 01 → 02 → 03 → 07 is one of the cleanest stacks; each layer fuels the next.
- **8. Treat your skill like an athlete treats a sport.** Daily reps, weekly review, quarterly reset. The market rewards training, not talent.
- **9. Pay the future-you tax.** Every week, do one thing only future-you will thank you for: a long-form post, a case study, a new GPT, a Loom asset. They compound.

"You don't get paid for what you know. You get paid for what you ship — and who can find you when they need it."

11. Close This. Open a Blank Doc.

If you remember one thing from this playbook, remember this: **the people who monetize are not the most talented. They are the ones who took action within 48 hours of finishing the workshop.** That window is right now.

Tonight • 60 minutes

- ☐ Pick one path (§3). Write it on paper.
- ☐ Pick one niche within it. Write it on paper.
- ☐ Write a one-line offer: "I help [niche] do [outcome] using [skill]."
- ☐ Update your LinkedIn headline to match.

This week

- ☐ Tell three people — out loud or in writing — what you're doing for the next 90 days.
- ☐ Build 3 spec pieces / case studies — fake-client, real-quality.
- ☐ Set up your minimum stack: Stripe invoicing, a Calendly link, LinkedIn featured.
- ☐ Start your outbound: 10 DMs/day, 5 emails/day, 3 posts/week.
- ☐ Bookmark this playbook and re-read it every 30 days.

Build, ship, get paid

The skills are in your head. The playbook is in your hands. The market is waiting. Everything you need is already on this device — the only thing missing is the next 90 days.

Share back: when you land your first paying client, post about it and tag @outskill. We celebrate every alumnus who ships — the next cohort needs to see your case study to believe what's possible.

Ship something this week. — Team Outskill